

DECODED EXPLAINED

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Noise Annoys: India Must Enforce Noise Rules Uniformly

Noise annoys

India must enforce noise pollution regulations uniformly and consistently

In a February 2025 hearing in the matter of *Surendra Prasad vs State of Bihar*, the Patna High Court acknowledged DJ trolleys and loudspeakers to be a major source of noise in Patna. After criticising the Bihar State Pollution Control Board (BSPCB) for failing to curb the menace, Justice Rajiv Roy directed the BSPCB to obtain reports from the police about permissions granted to operators of these noise sources and the action taken. In October, the police said they had seized equipment, levied fines, and so on over three months in Patna, Barh, and Patuha but had taken no action in Masaurhi, a picture Justice Roy called “unbelievable” for suggesting that there were no noise violations there. In the course of these hearings, Justice Roy also summoned police officers and upbraided boilerplate affidavits, among others. The High Court’s August 14 order was a continuation of this escalation, culminating – for now – in Statewide directives on the emission of high-decibel noise. Effectively, the High Court’s actions illustrate how dismal enforcement has become despite the existence of comprehensive laws. Courts have repeatedly said that people have a right under Article 21 to be protected from unlawful noise. Today, with episodic enforcement having become endemic, the Patna High Court becoming a quasi-regulator is, at least as a stopgap measure, creditable.

It is absurd to expect the public to complain about every DJ or horn before the police can respond. The High Court’s directions to the authorities to pursue routine rather than complaints-based enforcement and to have DJs, sound-system operators, and event halls register themselves with the subdivisional authorities are the sort of proactive enforcement that regulating noise pollution in particular warrants. In fact, the High Court’s order also touched on a practical, everyday understanding of how loud-noise violations occur when it directed loudspeakers to stop playing at 9.55 p.m., five minutes before the law’s 10 p.m. cut-off, effectively allowing time for operators to wind up rather than permit the deceptively innocuous practice of carrying on past 10 p.m. because “it is just a few minutes”. Loud noise is often produced by ordinary social events such as festivals, weddings, political campaigns, and religious events, and enforcing rules creates friction with people who believe they have a right to practise their culture as they deem fit. Also, governments have an incentive to tolerate, rather than antagonise, their constituents. At the same time, having operators register themselves so that officials can regulate all of them equally rather than sporadically can also eliminate selective interventions. In the final analysis, the success of the High Court’s latest order should be measured by whether the State develops a consistent habit of enforcement.

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The Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB), under the Noise Pollution (Regulation and Control) Rules, 2000, sets permissible noise limits for different zones such as industrial, commercial, residential, and silence zones.

Zone	Day time limit (6 AM - 10 PM)	Night time limit (10 PM - 6 AM)	Average of Indian Cities
Industrial	75 db	70 db	Chennai : 67.3 / 65.4
Commercial	65 db	55 db	Hyderabad : 68.4 / 66.0
Residential	55 db	45 db	Mumbai : 69.2 / 64.5
Silence Zone	50 db	40 db	Bengaluru : 68.9 / 69.2

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Noise Pollution Sources

- **Vehicular Traffic**
- **Industrial Activities**
- **Urbanization and Construction**
- **Social and Cultural Activities**
- **Air Traffic**

Impact of Noise Pollution

- **Hearing Loss: Long exposure above 85 dB can lead to permanent hearing damage.**
- **Sleep Disturbances**
- **Cardiovascular Diseases**
- **Mental Health Issues**
- **Child Development Issues**
- **Wildlife Disturbance: Bird communication gets disrupted, affecting breeding.**
- **Marine Noise Pollution**
- **Social Impact: Reduced quality of life in urban areas, increased complaints in residential colonies, and decline in property values in high-noise areas**

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Solution

- **Promotion of electric vehicles and improved public transport.**
- **Use of sound barriers and green belts along highways.**
- **Strict enforcement of permissible decibel limits in residential areas.**
- **Adoption of silent generators and machines in industries.**
- **Awareness campaigns to reduce honking and loudspeaker usage.**
- **Proactive enforcement and not complaint based enforcement**

Centre Notifies the Mobile Phone Manufacturing Scheme (MPMS)

Centre notifies key scheme to manufacture mobile phones

The ₹62,500 cr. scheme, offering incentives for Indian brands, was cleared by Cabinet last month; it builds on PLI Scheme for Large Scale Electronics Manufacturing which ran from 2020 to FY26

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) on Friday notified the Mobile Phone Manufacturing Scheme (MPMS), aimed at incentivising the domestic assembly of smartphones and greater local value addition in the process. "The time has come to focus on developing Indian brands," IT Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said at an event announcing the scheme's notification. "Indian brand, Indian design, Indian IP, that's the thought process."

The ₹62,500 crore scheme had been approved by the Union Cabinet on July 15, and continues an earlier scheme that ran from 2020 to the last financial year.

With the notification and the announcement, the Ministry provided some fresh information about how the scheme would be operationalised. For instance, phone makers receive additional incentives for sourcing certain parts domestically.

This is on top of the base incentive (tapering down from 2.75-2.25% over the five year tenure, with rates of 2.25-5% depending on the year and the incremental sales for the assembly itself). These additional incentives amount to 1-5% (with individual component incentives ranging



Union IT Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw, centre, addresses the media during the launch of the MPMS, in New Delhi on Friday. PTI

from 0.2-0.5%).

The 1.5% additional incentive would only be applicable if a firm is sourcing domestically for at least a quarter of the phones it sells in a given fiscal year.

While foreign phone makers face a higher bar to avail incentives, the corpus is fungible overall, meaning there is no earmarked amount as such for domestic players. Indian brands – which will need to be majority-owned by Indian citizens and incorporated in India, along with intellectual property and trademark held locally – will have a flat 3% incentive throughout the scheme's tenure, and are not subject to a minimum sales threshold applicable for other brands; they will have a baseline fixed at 2025-26.

Indian brands will also enjoy a domestic design and research and development incentive of 3%. Indian brands only need to demonstrate a ₹1,000 crore turnover, while others

need a minimum of ₹10,000 crore.

The scheme pushes expectant firms to grow production quickly. Incentives are only disbursed for sales that are beyond 115% of the production of the previous fiscal year. For instance, if a unit produced ₹10 crore worth of phones in the preceding fiscal and then ₹12 crore in the next, it would only be eligible for incentives on production of ₹50 lakh. Briefing reporters on the details of the scheme, IT Secretary S. Krishnan said that it would create 60,000 "direct" jobs.

"Domestic value addition in mobile phone manufacturing is at 23%, which is a substantial deepening" of the sector, Mr. Krishnan said. "Our goal of doubling overall domestic value addition from 18-22% to 35-40% will be achieved in the coming days." The latter target is in line with the value addition achieved by Chinese phone assembly units. The

number has a ceiling due to the global nature of electronics value chains, where various components crisscross the globe multiple times. Mr. Krishnan said that the phone manufacturing industry was important because "technology and skill transfer enables new sectors across the ecosystem [such as] laptops, gaming consoles, drone manufacturing, medical devices, components, tablets, smart watches and auto-mobile windshields."

A massive amount of phone assembly by firms like Apple and Samsung has moved into India, making India an exporter of finished handsets. "Around 70-75% of phones were imports in 2014-15, and now we're exporters," Mr. Krishnan pointed out.

"India is the second largest phone manufacturer in the world and practically all phones sold here are made here."

The government is aiming for ₹39 lakh crore in cumulative production (the combined sale value of the finished products) by the end of MPMS, which runs through 2030-31, and cumulative exports worth ₹15 lakh crore.

An empowered committee will make recommendations to the government on applications by Indian brands for incremental incentives, as well as any "non-fiscal" support from the government.

How India's Rs 62.5k cr scheme aims to scale mobile manufacturing, build domestic brands

Soumyarendra Barik
New Delhi, August 22

AFTER TURNING India into a major assembly hub for global smartphone makers – the Centre's new Rs 62,500 crore phone manufacturing scheme is attempting to tackle two unfinished parts of the country's electronics story: keeping large-scale production growing after the first smartphone production linked incentive (PLI) scheme has run its course, and creating Indian smartphone brands that can compete with the foreign companies dominating the domestic market.

The five-years scheme, which will run from FY 2026-27 to FY 2030-31, has consequently been split into two distinct tracks.

The first is designed as a successor to the earlier PLI programme, offering incentives to large manufacturers and electronics manufacturing services (EMS) companies for expanding production, while increasingly

linking benefits to the domestic sourcing of components. The second sets aside a separate incentive structure for Indian smartphone brands, offering higher support for companies that not only manufacture in the country but also keep their intellectual property, management control, design and research and development capabilities in India.

Keeping the PLI engine running

The first component is the direct successor to the smartphone PLI and is aimed at companies manufacturing at scale, including EMS companies.

To qualify, a manufacturer must have recorded at least Rs 10,000 crore in turnover in FY 2025-26. For existing brands, sales must increase by at least Rs 5,000 crore over FY26 levels in the first year, with the threshold rising cumulatively to Rs 10,000 crore in FY28, Rs 15,000 crore in FY29, Rs 20,000 crore in FY30

and Rs 25,000 crore in FY31. Unlike the original PLI, the baseline itself will also move every year: it will be calculated as the preceding financial year's sales plus 15%.

Incentives will then be paid on sales above this baseline, subject to the annual threshold being met. The thresholds are calculated on a brand-wise basis, and the sales counted towards them can include exports.

The new mobile phone manufacturing scheme builds on the central premise of PLI for smartphone makers: India will support manufacturers that can demonstrate scale and meaningful incremental production. Incumbents that have already built manufacturing capacity in India are therefore naturally positioned to benefit," Dhruv Shekhar, lead of manufacturing and supply chains at the Delhi-based consultancy firm Koan Advisory Group, told *The Indian Express*.

The quest for India's own Apple & Samsung

One of the more consequential aims of the new scheme is to incentivise the creation of a homegrown smartphone brand, a clear signal that the government's ambition for the electronics sector is moving beyond simply attracting factories and boosting assembly.

E. To qualify as an Indian brand under the scheme, a company must be incorporated in India; its trademark and intellectual property must be held in India; Indian

citizens must exercise management control and hold more than 51% of the entity; and it must have in-house design and R&D capabilities in the country. "The more interesting shift in the new scheme is that the government is no longer looking only at how many phone brands can manufacture, but at who actually owns and develops the

product... The Indian-brand track is an attempt to address that gap and, in some ways, rebuild the kind of domestic product capability that India had before foreign brands came to dominate the market," Shekhar said. As per the scheme details, eligible Indian brands will receive a 5% incentive on incremental sales.

Products designed and developed in India can receive an additional 3% for design and R&D, apart from the domestic sourcing incentive of up to 1.5%. Companies can also opt for a one-year gestation period, and the scheme leaves room for additional non-fiscal government support, which will be determined by a separate empowered committee.

The higher incentive structure is intended to offset some of the cost disadvantage a new Indian entrant would initially face against established global brands.

FULL REPORT ON
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Centre Notifies the Mobile Phone Manufacturing Scheme (MPMS)

- To boost domestic manufacturing capabilities by offering financial incentives to eligible companies based on their incremental sales.
- Covers 14 strategic sectors with a total financial outlay of ₹1.97 lakh crore.
- The 14 sectors are mobile manufacturing, manufacturing of medical devices, automobiles and auto components, pharmaceuticals, drugs, specialty steel, telecom & networking products, electronic products, white goods (ACs and LEDs), food products, textile products, solar PV modules, advanced chemistry cell (ACC) battery, and drones and drone components.
- The incentives given, are calculated on the basis of incremental sales

Key Issue

- The subsidy in the scheme for Mobile and allied Component Manufacturing is paid only for finishing the phone in India, not on how much value is added by manufacturing in India, turning out that very little apart from assembly is done in India.

PLI 2.0

Linking Incentives to Value Addition

Instead of rewarding companies solely based on incremental sales, PLI 2.0 proposes higher incentives for firms that achieve a greater percentage of domestic value addition. This includes:

Promoting localization of key components like semiconductors and printed circuit boards (PCBs).

Supporting indigenous R&D and manufacturing to reduce import dependence.

Ensuring Equity Amid India's Educational Progress

Ensuring equity amid India's educational progress

The Unified District Information System for Education Plus (UDISE+) 2025-26 report highlights notable progress in India's school education system, covering 1.47 million schools, 240 million students, and 10.2 million teachers. Progress has been recorded in gross enrolment, student retention, dropout reduction, teacher availability, and educational infrastructure. However, the report also shows that regional and social disparities persist in access, resources, learning opportunities, and educational outcomes. Disparities in gross enrolment rates (GER), dropout rates, pupil-teacher ratios, and infrastructure availability across regions and social groups indicate the ongoing challenge of guaranteeing equitable, inclusive, and quality education in India.

Regional and social imbalances

The report confirms that significant variations exist across socioeconomic groups and geographic regions in terms of various indicators. The distribution of enrolled students shows that Andhra Pradesh leads in Aadhaar seeding (99.6%), followed by Chandigarh (99%), while Meghalaya records the lowest rate (35%), compared with the national average of 90.2%. Uttar Pradesh accounts for the highest share of schools and student enrolment, while Meghalaya and Himachal Pradesh have the lowest shares of schools relative to enrolment, indicating higher student-school ratios.

At the school level, West Bengal has recorded the highest proportion of foundational and preparatory schools (79%) of total, and among the lowest secondary schools (0%); Chandigarh has the highest secondary schools (83%) and the lowest foundational and preparatory schools (5%) of total. The social composition of enrolled students shows significant variation across regions. Chandigarh and Delhi have the highest proportions of General category students, while Lakshadweep, Mizoram, Meghalaya, and Ladakh have high proportions of Schedule Tribe (ST) enrolment. Punjab records one of the highest shares of Scheduled Caste (SC) enrolment, whereas Other Backward Classes representation is particularly high in Tamil Nadu and Gujarat.

At the national level, the GER has recorded highest for OBCs (49%), followed by General (22%), SCs (07%), and STs (00%). Thus, GER indicates large differences in school education enrolment in comparison to their corresponding population of each social group.

The Gender Parity Index across all school levels shows higher girls' enrolment and participation than boys across most of the States/Union Territories. The UDISE+ data show that students from minority communities account for more than 20% of enrolment, with



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Muslims and Parsis among the major minority groups. The average enrolment per school shows that Chandigarh registers the highest average enrolment per school (1,194), followed by Delhi (788), while Ladakh records the lowest average enrolment (64), indicating variation in the size of the schools across the country.

The pupil-teacher ratio (PTR) is an important factor influencing students' performance and achievement. The PTR varies highly, registering lowest in Union Territories and highest in densely populated States. A significant inter-State variation in PTR exists across pedagogical stages, i.e., foundational, preparatory, and middle PTRs are generally lower than secondary across most of the States. Jharkhand records the highest Secondary PTR (43), followed by Uttar Pradesh, signifying a heavy workload on teachers. On the other hand, Sikkim has the lowest secondary PTR (6), followed by Ladakh. The GER varies significantly at the levels of schools and regions across the country. Meghalaya records the highest Foundational GER (31), followed by Mizoram, while Bihar has the lowest GER (24), preceded by Uttar Pradesh. Meghalaya again records the highest Preparatory GER (071), followed by Manipur; whereas Gujarat has the lowest GER (74), preceded by Bihar. Chandigarh and Meghalaya record the highest Middle GER (018), followed by Delhi. On the contrary, Bihar has the lowest GER (70), preceded by Nagaland. Similarly, Chandigarh registers the highest Secondary GER (009), followed by Goa; while Bihar has the lowest GER (48), preceded by Nagaland.

The dropout rate determines the attainment and transition rate to the next stage of schools. Bihar accounts for the highest preparatory dropout rate (7.9%), followed by Meghalaya. On the other hand, many States/Union Territories such as Delhi, Haryana and Maharashtra do not report dropout. Similarly, Bihar records the highest middle-level dropout rate (9%), followed by Uttar Pradesh. While several States/Union Territories such as Chandigarh, Maharashtra and Andhra Pradesh do not register dropouts at this stage, Ladakh records the highest secondary dropout rate (14.8%), followed by Karnataka. West Bengal has the lowest dropout rate (1.5%), preceded by Telangana.

Persistent gaps

Generally, access to schooling has improved significantly over the years. Most children now have a school at a suitable distance, but regional differences continue. Remotely located places, hilly, tribal and border areas still have limited schools and transport facilities, where school-going children face greater difficulties in attending school regularly, such as in Bageshwar district of Uttarakhand, Ganjam and Kandhamal districts of Odisha, Kathua district of Jammu and

Kashmir, and Palghar district of Maharashtra. Simultaneously, children from SCs, STs, minorities, and economically poor families have a greater likelihood to face different barriers that limit their enrolment, attendance, and completion of schooling.

School infrastructure has improved in several areas of the country, i.e., access to drinking water and electricity. However, the availability of infrastructure varies regionally across the country. Educationally backward districts are still struggling to provide a learning environment in rural schools in comparison to urban areas.

Teacher availability is a factor that significantly influences educational outcomes. The report shows that many States have recruited qualified teachers, while teacher shortages continue in several regions. Rural and remote schools often face a shortage of teachers performing multiple classes and subjects and many other non-teaching responsibilities allotted by the government. High student-teacher ratios reduce the individual attention students receive and adversely affect the learning process. Despite progress in girls' schooling, challenges persist in reducing dropout rates, enhancing transition from primary to secondary education, and providing sufficient and suitable facilities for disabled children. Inclusive infrastructure, accessible classrooms, and supportive teaching practices are essential for equitable education.

Targeted investment will help

The UDISE+ 2025-26 report shows that educational inequality persists across accessibility, infrastructure, teacher availability, digital resources, and social inclusion. Addressing these dimensions collectively is essential for equitable educational development. In line with the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020, targeted investment in educationally deprived regions, improved digital infrastructure, adequate teacher deployment, and stronger support for disadvantaged groups can help bridge persistent gaps.

Regional and social imbalances continue to influence educational opportunities and learning conditions. Reducing these disparities requires a balanced approach that collectively improves infrastructure, promotes equitable teacher deployment, strengthens inclusive social and economic policies, and provides dedicated support for disadvantaged social groups. A regionally and socially balanced approach that integrates educational quality, equity, and accessibility will help create a more inclusive education system, address the paradox of progress in India's evolving school education landscape, and contribute to the country's long-term social, economic, and regional development.

India's educational progress needs stronger focus on equity, inclusion, accessibility, and quality

Ensuring Equity Amid India's Educational Progress

- **The Ministry of Education (MoE) recently released the Unified District Information System for Education Plus (UDISE) 2025-26**
- **The Report**
 - **The UDISE 2025-26 report highlights notable progress in India's school system, covering 1.47 million schools, 240 million students, and 10.2 million teachers, with gains in enrolment, retention, dropout reduction, and infrastructure.**
 - **However, regional and social disparities persist in access, resources, learning opportunities, and outcomes across states and social groups.**

Pakistan Factor: Why West Asia War Hurt Indian Airlines More

Pakistan factor: Why West Asia war hurt Indian airlines more than foreign ones

Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, August 21

THE WEST Asia conflict, which resulted in major airspace disruptions in the Gulf region, led to a 9% year-on-year (y-o-y) decline in international air passenger traffic to and from India in the first quarter of the current financial year. While the fall in overall volumes was expected, notably, it was entirely driven by Indian airlines as they collectively lost a significant share of international passenger traffic. Overseas carriers, on the other hand, cumulatively made large market share gains, with their combined passenger numbers even higher than the year-ago period.

The odds were stacked against Indian airlines owing to a combination of factors. These include the heavy curtailment of flights to the United Arab Emirates and other West Asian markets — the biggest destinations for Indian airlines — and Indian carriers being forced to cut flights to destinations even beyond West Asia owing to the war-related financial headwinds and the ban on them from flying over Pakistan since late April of 2025. While the West Asia conflict-related challenges, like surging jet fuel prices, were also faced by overseas carriers, many of them had one key competitive advantage — availability of the Pakistani airspace.

Data on international air passengers

As per an analysis of the latest international passenger traffic data released by the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA), total international air passenger volume (to and from India) fell by 9.1% y-o-y in April-June to 1.72 crore. Indian carriers' combined international passenger numbers declined by 26.6% to 64.2 lakh, while foreign airlines expanded their cumulative passenger base by 6% to 1.08 crore from 1.02 crore a year ago. Consequently, foreign operators expanded their market share to 62.7% from 53.8%, while domestic carriers

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	Passengers*			Market Share(%)	
	APR-JUN 2026	APR-JUN 2025	CHANGE (%)	APR-JUN 2026	APR-JUN 2025
INDIAN AIRLINES	6414896	8734038	-26.6	37.3	46.2
FOREIGN AIRLINES	10785244	10178560	6.0	62.7	53.8
TOTAL	17200140	18912598	-9.1		

Source: DGCA; *based on air passengers carried by commercial airlines to and from India

dropped to 37.3% from 46.2%.

With the West Asia war leading to airspace closures in the region, Air India and IndiGo were forced to curtail their west-bound network as the unavailability of Pakistani

airspace made it financially and operationally unviable to maintain some flight services. Even before the West Asia war began late February, the two leading Indian carriers were reeling under pressure as the

Pakistani airspace closure forced them to take longer routes, and even introduce refuelling halts, on some of their West-bound routes from their major hub Delhi. Some routes also had to be suspended.

This provided an opportunity to overseas airlines, which became sweeter with the West Asia conflict. Once the war started, some carriers from Europe and other regions to the West of India increased flight operations to and from the country by deploying aircraft capacity that became spare owing to the curtailment in flights to West Asia.

Indian airlines' loss is foreign carriers' gain

IndiGo remained the largest Indian carrier for international routes but saw a 15.4% decline to 33.4 lakh international flyers in April-June. Its international market share slipped to 19.4% from 20.9%. Air India saw a 27.2% drop, falling to 19.3 lakh passengers, with the airline's international market share contracting to 11.2% from 14% a year ago. Air India Express, whose network is highly concentrated in West Asia, saw its international passenger footfall halve to 8.34 lakh. Its market share in the June quarter was 4.8%, sharply

down from 8.9% a year ago.

In all, the Air India group's international passenger traffic in the first quarter declined by 36.3% y-o-y to 27.61 lakh. SpiceJet, which has been struggling financially as well, saw the sharpest percentage decline at 56%, falling to 1.38 lakh flyers on its international flights, the analysis shows. The embattled carrier's international market share contracted to 0.8% from 1.7%.

The only Indian airline that registered higher international passenger numbers was Akasa Air, which has been growing its international network on a low base through its expanding fleet.

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